

The Sources for the Lost Books of Ammianus Marcellinus
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THE SOURCES FOR THE LOST BOOKS OF AMMIANUS MARCELLINUS

Ammianus Marcellinus concluded his history with the claim that he had explicated events "from the principate of the emperor Nerva" in 96 C.E. The *Res Gestae* as it exists today begins shortly after the defeat of Magnentius in 353 with book fourteen. The nature of the lost books has been a long-standing scholarly problem.[1] While he drew from a mixture of written and oral sources for the history of contemporary events, Ammianus' history of the second and third centuries must have stemmed from written sources. Knowledge of the sources he drew from for ancient history should provide insight into Ammianus' historical understanding and methods.

Ammianus covers twenty-five years of history in the eighteen extant books, roughly a year and a half per book. To cover the 257 years of history before book fourteen the historian would have averaged twenty years per book; even on the recent theory of Barnes, who claims that eighteen books were lost, the historian would have averaged fourteen years per book.[2] The lost books must have presented considerably less detail than the surviving ones. We are justified, then, in thinking of Ammianus as, first and foremost, a contemporary historian. Ancient history was valuable to him as a precursor to the events of his own time, but did not motivate him to undertake his task.

What might we speculate about Ammianus' method in writing the lost books? Ancient historians sought to improve upon their predecessors by an elevation of style and their own judgment and commentary upon ancient events. Livy is paradigmatic here. In his survey of the subject, John Marincola states that "... it is fair to say that the 'methodology' of non-contemporary history was to consult the tradition, what previous writers had handed down."[3] Because ancient history was not Ammianus' primary focus, we may also expect that the sources he used were both limited in number and fully exploited, which makes the search for them more likely to be successful.

Lacking extant authors who used Ammianus' lost books, we are forced to probe the nature of the books through study of Ammianus' surviving text alone. The historian makes frequent reference to people and events of the second, third, and first half of the

1 The literature is vast. One may begin with the debate between H. Michael, *Die verlorenen Bücher des Ammianus Marcellinus* (Breslau 1880) and L. Jeep, "Die verlorenen Bücher des Ammianus Marcellinus," *RhM* 43 (1888) 60–72; see also H.T. Rowell, "The First Mention of Rome in Ammianus' Extant Books and the Nature of the History," in *Mélanges d'archéologie, d'épigraphie et d'histoire offerts à Jérôme Carcopino* (Paris 1966) 839–848; J.F. Gilliam, "Ammianus and the Historia Augusta: the lost books and the period 117–284," in A. Alföldi/J. Straub (eds.), *Bonner Historia-Augusta-Colloquium 1970* (Bonn 1972) 125–147; A. Emmett, "The Digressions in the Lost Books of Ammianus Marcellinus," in B. Croke/A. Emmett (eds.), *History and Historians in Late Antiquity* (Sydney 1983) 42–53; J.F. Matthews, *The Roman Empire of Ammianus* (London 1989) 27–30; R.M. Frakes, "Cross-References to the Lost Books of Ammianus Marcellinus," *Phoenix* 49 (1995) 232–246; T.D. Barnes, *Ammianus Marcellinus and the Representation of Historical Reality* (Ithaca, NY/London 1998) 213–217; and R.M. Frakes, "Some Thoughts on the Length of the Lost Books of Ammianus Marcellinus," *AW* 31 (2000) 48–53, which contains further bibliography.

2 Matthews, *Roman Empire* (as in n. 1) 27–30; Barnes, *Ammianus* (as in n. 1) 23–26.

3 J. Marincola, *Authority and Tradition in Ancient Historiography* (Cambridge 1997) 105.

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fourth century.[4] Many of these references are purely conventional, such as a description of Antoninus Pius as *clemens* (16.1.4), and thus can shed no light on the sources of the lost books. Robert Frakes has demonstrated that many other references to second- and third-century history in the *Res Gestae* should not be classified as true "cross-references" to the lost books, but are merely "historical allusions."[5] These allusions are not evidence for the specific content of the lost books but, if considered carefully, they may still provide suggestive information on Ammianus' sources for the lost books. For example, at 14.11.10 Ammianus claims that the Caesar Galerius once walked for a mile before the chariot of Diocletian as a punishment. This is not a true cross-reference, and Ammianus may not have discussed this event in his account of Galerius. I argue below, however, that the anecdote is derived from the source known as "Enmann's *Kaisergeschichte*," and thus it provides evidence that Ammianus was familiar with that work. We are then justified in searching for other instances where Ammianus may have used this source, and in considering it, at least tentatively, as a source for the lost books.

To determine Ammianus' sources for the lost books we must compare his work with that of other ancient historians who cover the period, such as Eutropius, Aurelius Victor, Jerome, and Zosimus. This requires that we enter into some of the controversies over the interrelationships between the various sources, many of which are dealt with below in their proper place. At the outset, however, it is impossible to sidestep the thorny question of the sources for the *Historia Augusta*, the fraudulent collection of biographies of the second and third century emperors, which purports to be the work of many hands writing at the time of Constantine, but which is in fact the work of a single author writing at the very end of the fourth century.[6] The early biographies of the *HA* are clearly superior to the later ones. Information for these biographies was drawn from Herodian (where applicable) and from the lost biographer Marius Maximus (below, II). Some have argued that the main source of these biographies is a lost biographer, dubbed "Ignotus" by Syme.[7] Following Birley, I reject this theory and believe that Marius Maximus is the major source for the early lives. "Ignotus" is too often defined in a circular fashion, as the source responsible for what is trustworthy in the *HA*. The need for "Ignotus" is predicated on an unnecessarily pessimistic view of the quality of Maximus' work. Evidence for "Ignotus" is often found in doublets or repetitions in the sloppily constructed biographies of the *HA*, but the greatest doublet of all would surely be this shadowy, parallel biographer who covers almost the same ground as Maximus. Birley has convincingly dispensed of the main arguments for "Ignotus," but I emphasize just one which was not available to Syme.[8] The twelve poems on emperors

4 Gilliam, *Ammianus* (as in n. 1) is especially helpful here, although he formally notes only passages which chronologically parallel the *Historia Augusta*.

5 Frakes, *Cross-References* (as in n. 1).

6 Here, too, the literature is vast. The starting point is T.D. Barnes, *The Sources of the Historia Augusta* (Brussels 1978), with reflections, discussion, and full bibliography at T.D. Barnes, "The Sources of the Historia Augusta (1967–1992)," in G. Bonamente/G. Paci (eds.), *Historiae Augustae Colloquium Maceratense* (Bari 1995) 1–28.

7 On "Ignotus" and Marius Maximus, in addition to the works of Barnes cited in the previous note, see R. Syme, *Emperors and Biography* (Oxford 1971) and H. Benario, "'Ignotus,' the 'Good Biographer'," *ANRW* II.34.3 (1997) 2759–2772 in favor of "Ignotus," and A. Cameron, "Ammianus and the Historia Augusta," *JRS* 61 (1971) 255–267 and A.R. Birley, "Marius Maximus, the Consular Biographer," *ANRW* II.34.3 (1997) 2679–2757 against.

8 Birley, *Marius Maximus* (as in n. 7) 2713–2714.

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preserved in Ausonius' *Caesares* were once thought to be evidence for the twelve biographies of Marius Maximus, but they are now known to have been derived not from Maximus, but from "Eusebius of Nantes," the author of the *KG* (below, I), and thus provide no evidence as to the limits of Maximus' work.[9] Despite my rejection of "Ignotus," believers in his existence may still follow the argument below, simply substituting "Ignotus or Marius Maximus" for the passages I ascribe to Maximus alone.

Below I study the significant back-references and historical allusions found in Ammianus' surviving books. I argue that Ammianus had two basic narrative sources which he followed at least up to the reign of Constantine, namely Marius Maximus to the reign of Elagabalus and Enmann's *Kaisergeschichte* thereafter. I suggest that a few additional bits of information from Ammianus' contemporary, the historian Eunapius, or from the posited Latin source of Eunapius called the *Leoquelle*, explain the points of intersection between Ammianus' lost books and the Greek tradition. Otherwise, Ammianus seems ignorant of the major Greek historians of the period, Herodian, Dio, and Dexippus.

I. Enmann's *Kaisergeschichte*

Enmann suggested that a lost work, which he called the *Kaisergeschichte* (the *KG*), was the economical way to explain the fact that Aurelius Victor and Eutropius share similar errors, and that, although Victor wrote earlier than Eutropius, Eutropius sometimes provides more information. Since Enmann's work, the nature, scope, and influence of the *KG* have been increasingly refined.[10] The *KG* was a short work, biographical in nature, covering the period from Augustus to 357. It was written in Gaul by Eusebius of Nantes, and was used as a source by Victor, Eutropius, Festus, the anonymous *Epitome de Caesaribus*, the *Historia Augusta*, Jerome in his *Chronicon*, Ausonius in his *Caesares*, and the *Laterculus* of Polemius Silvius. Fortunately for investigators, it contains numerous errors, which aid in its detection. The widespread use of the *KG*, despite its brevity and inaccuracy, provides powerful evidence for the paucity of information on the second and particularly the third centuries in the Latin tradition.

Several scholars have suggested that Ammianus used the work, but no one has attempted to lay out the evidence fully.[11] The following passages in Ammianus may derive from the *KG*:

9 R.P.H. Green, "Marius Maximus and Ausonius' *Caesares*," *CQ* NS 31 (1981) 226–236; R.W. Burgess, "*Principes cum Tyrannis*: Two Studies on the *Kaisergeschichte* and its Tradition," *CQ* NS 43 (1993) 491–500.

10 Of the extensive literature, see A. Enmann, "Eine verlorene geschichte der römischen kaiser und das buch De viris illustribus urbis Romae. Quellenstudien," *Philologus* Supplementband 4 (1884) 335–501; T.D. Barnes, "The lost Kaisergeschichte and the Latin Historical Tradition," in G. Alföldy/J. Straub (eds.), *Bonner Historia-Augusta-Colloquium 1968/1969* (Bonn 1970) 13–43; Id., "The *Epitome de Caesaribus* and Its Sources," *CP* 71 (1976) 258–268; Id., *Sources (1978)* (as in n. 6.); H.W. Bird, "Further Observations on the Dating of Enmann's Kaisergeschichte," *CQ* NS 23 (1973) 375–377; Id., *Eutropius: Breviarium ab Urbe Condita* (Liverpool 1992); Id., *Aurelius Victor: De Caesaribus* (Liverpool 1994); Burgess, *Principes* (as in n. 9); Id., "Jerome and the *Kaisergeschichte*," *Historia* 44 (1995) 349–369; Id., "On the Date of the *Kaisergeschichte*," *CP* 90 (1995) 111–128; G. Zecchini, "Qualche ulteriore riflessione su Eusebio di Nantes e l'EKG," in F. Paschoud (ed.), *Historiae Augustae Colloquium Genevense* (Bari 1998) 331–344.

11 Matthews, *Roman Empire* (as in n. 1) 29–30; Burgess, *Jerome* (as in n. 10) 350 n. 9.

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1. 14.11.10 *quibus subserebat non adeo vetus exemplum, quod Diocletiano et eius collegae ut apparitores Caesares non resides, sed ultro citroque discurrentes obtemperabant et in Syria Augusti vehiculum irascentis per spatium mille passuum fere pedes antegressus est Galerius purpuratus.*

This anecdote is found only in Latin sources which draw from the *KG*, as Schwartz has shown: Festus 25, Eutropius 9.24, Jerome 227c.[12] The Jerome passage is an insertion into the original Eusebian *Chronicon*.[13]

2. 15.5.18 *Diocletianus enim Augustus omnium primus externo et regio more instituit adorari, cum semper antea ad similitudinem iudicum salutatos principes legerimus.*

Alföldi demonstrated that this passage was found in the *KG*, comparing Ammianus with Victor 39.1-4, Eutropius 9.26, and Jerome 226c.[14]

3. a. 30.8.8 *aviditas plus habendi ... exundavit in hoc principe [Valentiniano] flagrantius adolescens. quam quidam praetendentes imperatorem Aurelianum purgare temptabant id affirmando, quod, ut ille post Gallienum et lamentabiles rei publicae casus exinanito aerario torrentis ritu ferebatur in divites ...*
   b. 26.6.7 *Petronius ... animo deformis et habitu, qui ad nudandos sine discretione cunctos immaniter flagrans nocentes pariter et insontes post exquisita tormenta quadrupli nexibus vinciebat, debita iam inde a temporibus principis Aureliani perscrutans et impendio maerens, si quemquam absoluisset indemnem.*

The Greek tradition is favorable towards Aurelian,[15] while the *KG* is hostile. Ammianus' claim that Aurelian "fell upon the rich like a torrent" is best mirrored by Eutropius 9.14 *plurimos nobiles capite damnavit*, but see also Victor 35.6, *HA Aur.* 38.2, *Epit.* 35.9.[16] For Gallienus, see below.

Petronius' search for records back to the time of Aurelian could easily be a contemporary fact which Ammianus had learned, but Aurelian's destruction of tax records was noted in the *KG*: Victor 35.7, *HA Aur.* 39.4.

4. 21.16.9-10 ... *[Constantius] in eiusmodi controversiarum partibus etiam Gallieno ferocior. 10. ille enim perduellionum crebis verisque appetitus insidiis, Aureoli et Postumi et Ingenui et Valentis cognomento Thessalonici aliorumque plurium, mortem factura crimina aliquotiens lenius vindicabat.*

Of the four usurpers mentioned here, three were certainly discussed in the *KG*: Ingenuus (Victor 33.2 [misspelled as Ingebus], Eutropius 9.8.1, *HA Tyr. Trig.* 9), Postumus

12 J. Schwartz, "Autour de l'«humiliation» de Galère" in *Mélanges d'histoire ancienne offerts à William Seston* (Paris 1974) 463–466.

13 Burgess, *Jerome* (as in n. 10) 366.

14 A. Alföldi, "Die Ausgestaltung des monarchischen Zeremoniells am oströmischen Kaiserhofe," *Mitteilungen der Römischen Abteilung des Deutschen Archäologischen Institutes* 49 (1934) 6; W.T. Avery, "The *Adoratio Purpurae* and the Importance of the Imperial Purple in the Fourth Century of the Christian Era," *MAAR* 17 (1942) 66–80. Avery's discussion is needlessly confused by the erroneous belief that Lactantius drew upon the *KG*. See also Burgess, *Jerome* (as in n. 10) 366.

15 E.g., D.F. Buck, "The Reign of Aurelian in Eunapius' Histories," *AHB* 61 (1995) 255–267.

16 W.H. Fisher, "The Augustan Vita Aureliani," *JRS* 19 (1929) 125–149 has reconstructed the *KG* version of the life of Aurelian. Its conclusion seems overly harsh given the generally moderate account in the main narrative. Perhaps our sources have omitted other critical comments?

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(Victor 33.8, Eutropius 9.9.1, *HA Tyr. Trig.* 3), and Aureolus[17] (Victor 33.17, *HA Tyr. Trig.* 11.) The author of the *KG* had a particular interest in usurpers, an interest which the author of the *Historia Augusta* appropriated and parodied in the *Tyranni Triginta* and elsewhere. Among the "tyranni" one finds a Valens (*Tyr. Trig.* 19) followed by Valens Superior (*Tyr. Trig.* 20), the latter apparently Julius Valens Licinianus, a usurper from the time of Decius. The author of the *HA* claims that Valens Superior was perhaps the great-uncle of the Valens who usurped under Gallienus. The inclusion of Valens Superior, who does not properly belong in the list of usurpers under Gallienus, suggests strongly that the original Valens was found in the *HA's* source, the *KG*. One can easily imagine the author being inspired by the real Valens to pad his list with the Valens of a previous generation; the invention of the first Valens followed by another real but anachronistic Valens seems to require a byzantine complexity beyond the reach of the author of the *HA*. Valens is also found in *HA Gall.* 2. In neither place in the *Historia Augusta* does he have the surname "Thessalonicus." Instead, the *Historia Augusta* claims that a certain Piso, an invention of the author (cf. *Tyr. Trig.* 21), was commissioned to attack Valens but instead withdrew into Thessaly and, being himself crowned emperor, was given the surname Thessalonicus. This is presumably a fiction woven by the author of the *HA* around the simple *KG* original preserved by Ammianus.

The *KG* is hostile toward Gallienus, while the Greek tradition is more positive. Of five mentions of the emperor in Ammianus, four are clearly hostile (14.1.9, 18.6.3, 21.16.9, 23.5.3, 30.8.8). Stephen Stertz has argued that this passage is more favorable toward the emperor, and thus suggests that Ammianus drew from Greek sources as well as Latin ones.[18] This misinterprets Ammianus' aims here. He argues that Constantius is very cruel, even crueller than the notoriously cruel Gallienus; while both ruthlessly suppressed their enemies, at least Gallienus faced real threats and was occasionally lenient. The comparison has force as an attack on Constantius only to the extent that Gallienus is thought to be a paragon of cruelty.

5. a. 16.10.3 *[Constantius] ignorans fortasse quosdam veterum principum in pace quidem lictoribus fuisse contentos, ubi vero proeliorum ardor nihil perpeti peterat segne, alium anhelante rabido flatu ventorum lenunculo se commisisse piscantis, alium ad Deciorum exempla vovisse pro re publica spiritum, alium hostilia castra per semet ipsum cum militibus infimis explorasse, diversos denique actibus inclaruisse magnificis, ut glorias suas posteritatis celebri memoriae commendarent.*
   b. 31.5.17 *... sed assumpto in imperium Claudio, glorioso ductore, et eodem honesta morte praerepto ...*

Claudius II died of the plague at Sirmium in 270 (Zos. 1.43.1-2, Zon. 12.26.) The Greek sources which preserve this information presumably derived it ultimately from Claudius' contemporary, Dexippus.[19] The heroic sacrifice of the emperor is a fourth-century

17 Cf. M. Christol, "Auréolus et l'Histoire Auguste" in G. Bonamente et al. (eds.), *Historiae Augustae Colloquium Argentoratense* (Bari 1998) 115–135.

18 S. Stertz, "Ammianus Marcellinus on the Emperor Gallienus: His Sources," *AW* 2 (1979) 69–71; Id., "Ammianus Marcellinus' Attitudes Toward Earlier Emperors", in C. Deroux (ed.), *Studies in Latin Literature and Roman History* II (Brussels 1980) 508.

19 A. Chastagnol, *Histoire Auguste* (Paris 1994): 926–927. The *HA* derives its knowledge of the truth from Dexippus as well, as the inclusion of the consular date in the the *Life* of Claudius suggests: R. Syme, *Historia Augusta Papers* (Oxford 1983) 69–70.

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myth which, one imagines, followed in the trail of the "discovery" that Claudius was actually the grandfather of the usurping and ignoble emperor Constantine.[20] The mythological version appears in Victor 34.3-4 and the *Epitome* 34.3, whereas the real version appears in Eut. 9.11 and the *Life* of Claudius in the *Historia Augusta*. Perhaps the *KG* offered both possibilities, with Victor choosing the more colorful variant which was also politically advisable during the reign of Constantius II and Eutropius choosing the more sober variant with the house of Constantine no longer in power. The author of the *HA* mocks the story: *Claudi, dux fortissime, aveas! virtutibus tuis devotioni tuae!* (*Claud.* 18), perhaps out of hatred for Constantine and Christianity.[21] Ammianus, too, hated Constantine and Christianity, but his acceptance of the story here has a different purpose. In each case, he seeks to portray Christian emperors as indolent and self-serving by highlighting the courage of an emperor of the past.

The emperor who entered the Persian camp in person in 16.10.3 was Galerius. The story was also in the *KG* (Eut. 9.25).

6. a. 23.5.7 *Profecti exinde Zaithan venimus locum, qui olea arbor interpretatur. hic Gordiani imperatoris longe conspicuum vidimus tumulum, cuius actus a pueritia prima exercituumque felicissimos ductus et insidiosum interitum digessimus tempore competenti.*
   b. 23.5.17 [Julian addresses the troops] *sed ut a vetustate discedam, haec, quae tradidit recens memoria, replicabo. Traianus et Verus, Severus hinc sunt digressi victores et tropeati redissetque pari splendore iunior Gordianus, cuius monumentum nunc vidimus honorate, apud Resainan superato fugatoque rege Persarum, ni factione Philippi praefecti praetorio sceleste iuvantibus paucis in hoc, ubi sepultus est, loco vulnere impio cecidisset. nec erravere diu manes eius inulti, quod veluti librante iustitia omnes, qui in eius ... conspiravere, crucialibus interiere suppliciis.*
   c. 26.6.20 *in Africa superior Gordianus in imperium raptus adventantium periculorum angoribus implicatus vitam laqueo spiritu intercluso profudit.*
   d. 14.1.8 *[Gallus] adolescebat autem obstinatum propositum erga haec et similia multa scrutandi stimulos admovente regina, quae abrupte mariti fortunas trudebat in exitium praeceps, cum eum potius lenitate feminea ad veritatis humanitatisque viam reducere utilia suadendo deberet, ut in Gordianorum actibus factitasse Maximini truculenti illius imperatoris rettulimus coniugem.*

Ammianus' knowledge of the reigns of the Gordians presents a difficult problem, but one of great importance for reconstructing the sources of the lost books. Most significant is his belief that there were two, not three Gordians (*superior* and *iunior*.)[22] This is a serious error which no reader of Dexippus or Herodian could make. Indeed, the only known source to make this error is the *KG*, and the works derived from it. The *HA*, which did use those Greek writers or a source drawing from them, makes a point of mocking *imperiti scriptores*, i.e. the *KG*, for their ignorance: *Gordiani non, ut quidam*

20 *XII Pan. Lat.* 6.2.1; H.W. Bird, "The *Historia Augusta* on Constantine's Lineage," *Arctos* 31 (1997) 9–17.

21 Bird, *Historia Augusta* (as in n. 20) 16.

22 C.E.V. Nixon, "An Historiographical Study of the Caesares of Sextus Aurelius Victor," (diss., Ann Arbor, Michigan 1971) 256–9; D.S. Potter, *Prophecy and History in the Crisis of the Roman Empire* (Oxford 1990) 189–212.

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imperiti scriptores loquuntur, duo sed tres fuerunt, idque docente Arriano [= Herodian], scriptore Graecae historiae, docente item Dexippo, Graeco auctore, poterunt addiscere, qui, etiamsi breviter, ad fidem tamen omnia persecuti sunt (*HA Gord.* 2.1).[23] Further evidence, perhaps, of the brief treatment the Gordians received in the lost books is to be found in 14.1.8, where we learn that Maximinus did not receive his own section in the work but was subsumed *in Gordianorum actibus*.

Sources dependent upon the *KG* follow the pattern of 23.5.7 in providing details of the childhood of Gordian III, his Persian campaign, presented as a great success, and his murder at the instigation of Philip (Victor 27; Eut. 9.2; Festus 22.2; *Epit.* 27.3). Ammianus seems to know a few details of the life of Gordian III not reported by the historians of the *KG* tradition, however: the battle at Resaina and the awful fates of the conspirators. He also reports that Gordian I died by hanging, a true detail which the *KG* may have lacked. I return to the Gordians again below, IV.3.

7. 31.5.15 *duobus navium milibus perrupto Bosporo et litoribus Propontidis Scythicarum gentium catervae transgressae ediderunt quidem acerbas terra marique strages, sed amissa suorum parte maxima reverterunt.*

My attribution of this passage to the *KG* is admittedly speculative. The figure of 2000 ships recurs in *HA Claud.* 8.2, whereas Zosimus 1.42 gives the figure 6000. None of the other *KG* sources provides a figure. The wretched *Life* of Claudius contains almost nothing of value, and it seems that the author merely padded the small bits of knowledge he garnered from the *KG* with phony documents, acclamations, and genealogies. The *KG*, for example, had noted that the senate awarded the emperor a gold shield and gold statue (Eut. 9.11; *Epit.* 34.4); the author of the *HA* notes this uninteresting fact no less than three times (3.3-7, 7.6, 18.2). I suspect, then, that the figure was found in the *KG* and simply not recorded by the breviarists.

II. Marius Maximus

The career of Marius Maximus is known from extensive epigraphic evidence and from the work of Dio.[24] Fragments of his lost biographies have been collected from a *scholium* on Juvenal and from frequent citations in the early biographies of the *Historia Augusta*. Obvious problems arise in the interpretation of this material. The author of the *Historia Augusta* is not necessarily reliable, and is certainly selective in his citations. Given the penchant of the author of the *HA* for inventing sources and Ammianus' association of Maximus with Juvenal, François Paschoud has even floated the idea that Maximus was not a biographer at all, but perhaps a poet discovered in the *scholia* on Juvenal by the *HA* author and pressed into service as a historian.[25] Such revisionism is ultimately unconvincing. The traditional picture of a Maximus who wrote *Lives* of twelve emperors following Suetonius, from Nerva to Elegabalus, fits the pattern of citations which the *HA* provides us, as well as the details of the life of Maximus which

23 Alternatively the *HA* may be referring to itself, since it several times suggests there were only two Gordians, in sections deriving from the *KG*: *Macr.* 3.5, *Diad.* 6.3, *Elag.* 34.6.

24 Birley, *Marius Maximus* (as in n. 7), with bibliography.

25 F. Paschoud, "Propos sceptiques et iconoclastes sur Marius Maximus," in F. Paschoud (ed.), *Historiae Augustae Colloquium Genevense* (Bari 1998) 241–254.

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are independently preserved. Coincident with the end of Maximus-citations is a sharp decline in the historical quality of the biographies. Birley's survey of the fragments offers a coherent, self-consistent picture. None of this would be expected were Maximus the invention of the slapdash author of the *HA*. And once this traditional outline is accepted, the arguments of Birley follow persuasively, even if always tentatively.[26]

I see Marius Maximus, then, as the major source for the first part of the *HA*. Maximus was also a source for the *KG*, as suggested by the correlation between Eut. 8.9.1 and *HA Marcus* 1.6, which is specifically attributed to him, and perhaps also a source for the anonymous *Epitome de Caesaribus*.[27]

At 28.4.14, Ammianus complains that the decadent Romans of his day read nothing but Juvenal and Marius Maximus: *quidam detestantes ut venena doctrinas Iuvenalem et Marium Maximum curatiore studio legunt, nulla volumina praeter haec in profundo otio contrectantes, quam ob causam non iudicioli est nostri* ... This has puzzled many readers, who have failed to appreciate the humor in the comment of the admittedly rarely humorous Ammianus. The aristocrats read authors whose subject matter mirrors their disgraceful lives, although they are presumably too dense to appreciate that the authors are criticizing this sort of behavior. It is thus unwarranted to claim that Ammianus "detested" Marius Maximus,[28] and it is likewise unnecessary to point out that aristocrats might have read Marius Maximus for reasons of personal prosopography.[29] That Ammianus does not intend to criticize Juvenal is clear from the overall Juvenalian feel of his two Roman digressions and by a few specific Juvenalian allusions which have been detected in them.[30] We might similarly find allusions to Maximus in the digressions, should more of his work have survived.[31]

Since we know that Ammianus was familiar with Marius Maximus, and since his extensive work covered a large part of the period covered in the lost books, we might reasonably hope to find traces of the biographer in Ammianus' references to the period between 96 and 222. The attribution of passages to Maximus must, of course, be tentative; the most one could say with full certainty about these passages is that they are not inconsistent with our understanding of the author. Nevertheless, I think that the accumulation of circumstantial argument is convincing. Passages echoed by Herodian or Dio are discussed in further detail in section III.

26 Paschoud, *Marius Maximus* (as in n. 25) 243 n. 4 also argues that it is striking that the two mentions of Marius Maximus outside of the *HA* both associate the author with Juvenal: the *scholium* on Juvenal, and the passage of Ammianus discussed below. Since Ammianus reveals that Juvenal and Marius Maximus were both popular authors in the late fourth century, it seems unsurprising that the contemporary scholiast would turn to Maximus' biography of Nerva to explicate a particular passage in Juvenal. Certainly nothing in the *scholium* would be out of place in a biography of the emperor.

27 J. Schlumberger, *Die Epitome de Caesaribus* (Munich 1974) 78–123.

28 Stertz, *Ammianus Marcellinus' Attitudes* (as in n. 18).

29 A.R. Birley, "Indirect Means of Tracing Marius Maximus," in G. Bonamente/G. Paci (eds.), *Historiae Augustae Colloquium Maceratense* (Bari 1995) 58–60.

30 E.A. Thompson, *The Historical Work of Ammianus Marcellinus* (Cambridge 1947) 15 n. 1; R. Rees, "Ammianus Satiricus," in J.W. Drijvers/D. Hunt (eds.), *The Late Roman World and its Historian* (London 1999) 141–155.

31 The negative comments about Marius Maximus in the *Historia Augusta* may also have influenced judgements of the work (*Quadr. Tyr.* 1.2), although the author's opinions on historiography are hardly to be taken seriously.

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1. 28.4.21 ... *unde quidam ex his gregibus inveniuntur ita concordes, ut Quintilios esse existimes fratres.*

Cf. *HA Comm.* 4.9, *domus praeterea Quintiliorum omnis exstincta, quod Sextus Condiani filius specie mortis ad defectionem diceretur evasisse.* See also below, III.2.

2. 26.6.20 *sic Antiochiae Macrino imperatore agente ab Emesa Heliogabalus exsiluit Antoninus. ita inopino impetu Maximini Alexander cum Mamaea matre confossus est.*

Nothing here is so specific or unusual that a particular source needs to be located, but note that Victor 24 and Eut. 8.23 merely emphasize the closeness of Alexander and his mother, while the *Epitome* 24.4-5 and especially *HA Alex.* 60.1, who have direct access to Marius Maximus, are more clear on the fact that both were killed together.

3. 26.8.15 *ut quondam Pescennius Niger ad subveniendum spei rerum extremae a Romano populo saepe accitus, dum diu cunctatur in Syria, a Severo superatus in sinu Issico, qui est in Cilicia, ubi Dareum Alexander fudit, fugatusque in suburbano quodam Antiochiae gregarii manu militis interiit.*

Bird and then Birley have discussed this passage at length.[32] Eutropius (8.18), Victor (20.8), and the *HA Sev.* 9.1 and *Pesc. Nig.* 5.8 all erroneously place the death of Niger in Cyzicus. Since Maximus was the commander of the forces who defeated Niger, he could hardly have been mistaken on this point. Shortly before Niger's death he was defeated in a battle at Cyzicus, and thus the compiler of the *KG* must have made the error in epitomizing Maximus' no doubt lengthy account. Ammianus preserves the correct version, implying use of the full work of Maximus here.

4. 14.4.2 *super quorum [Saracenorum] moribus licet in actibus principis Marci et postea aliquotiens memini rettulisse, tamen nunc quoque pauca de isdem expediam carptim.*

Ammianus' digression on the Saracens in the reign of Marcus was probably drawn from a separate ethnographic source, but Maximus may have provided the opportunity for such a digression in his discussion of Avidius Cassius' campaigns in Egypt against the Boucolici, mentioned in *HA Marcus* 21.2 and attributed to Maximus in *HA Av. Cass.* 6.7.

5. 22.15.1 *Strictim itaque, quoniam tempus videtur hoc flagitare, res Aegyptiacae tangantur, quarum notitiam in actibus Hadriani et Severi principum digessimus late visa pleraque narrantes.*

Again the material in the digression probably derived from autopsy or other sources, but the opportunity for such digressions would have been offered by Maximus' narrative. Hadrian was in Egypt in 130. The *HA* "attests Septimius' fascination with Egypt," according to Birley (*HA Sev.* 17.3-4).[33] Severus was a devotee of Serapis, but Ammianus' discussion of the Serapaeum at 22.16.12-13 somewhat surprisingly does not seem to follow upon a previous discussion.

32 H.W. Bird, "A Strange Aggregate of Errors for A.D. 193," *CB* 65 (1989) 95–98; Birley, *Marius Maximus* (as in n. 7) 2713.

33 A.R. Birley, *Septimius Severus* (Oxford 1989) 135.

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6. 25.8.5 *hac etiam suspicione iam liberi properantesque itineribus magnis prope Hatram venimus, vetus oppidum in media solitudine positum olimque desertum, quod eruendum adorti temporibus variis Traianus et Severus principes bellicosi cum exercitibus paene deleti sunt, ut in eorum actibus has quoque digessimus partes.*

While the *HA* does not mention Hatra specifically, it says that Maximus discussed in detail the execution of Laetus (*HA Sev.* 15.6); this execution took place during the siege of the city.

7. 22.9.5-6 *... per Nicaeam venit ad Gallograeciae fines, unde dextrorsus itinere declinato Pessinunta convertit visurus vetusta Matris Magnae delubra, a quo oppido bello Punico translatum est Romam. 6. cuius super adventu in Italiam pauca cum aliis huic materiae congruentibus in actibus Commodi principis digessimus per excessum.*

The digression would have been appropriate in the context of the plot of Maternus, which transpired during the festival of the Magna Mater. See more below, III.1.

8. 23.6.24 *qua [Seleucia] per duces Veri Caesaris, ut ante rettulimus, expulsata avulsum sedibus simulacrum Comaei Apollinis perlatumque Romam in aede Apollinis Palatini deorum antistites collocarunt. fertur autem, quod post direptum hoc idem figmentum incensa civitate milites fanum scrutantes invenere foramen angustum, quo reserato, ut pretiosum aliquid invenirent, ex adyto quodam concluso a Chaldaeorum arcanis labes primordialis exsiluit, quae insanabilium vi concepta morborum eiusdem Veri Marcique Antonini temporibus ab ipsis Persarum finibus ad usque Rhenum et Gallias cuncta contagiis polluebat et mortibus.*

Burgess compares Eut. 8.12.2, Jerome 206h and 205f, and *HA Marc.* 13.3.[34] The first two writers used the *KG*, and the author of the *HA* may have taken the phrase from the *KG* or from its source, Marius Maximus. The *HA Marc.* further discusses the evils of the plague at 17.2, 21.6-7, and 28.4. Dio's account is not extant, but he describes the plague under Commodus, for which he was an eyewitness, as the "worst ever" (72.14.3), and cf. Herodian 1.12.1-2.[35] Thus the connection of the horrors of the plague with Marcus, rather than with Commodus, may be attributed to Maximus.Compare the Ammianus passage with *HA Verus* 8.1-4: *Fuit eius fati ut in eas provincias per quas rediit Romam usque luem secum deferre videretur. et nata fertur pestilentia in Babylonia, ubi de templo Apollinis ex arcula aurea, quam miles forte inciderat, spiritus pestilens evasit, atque inde Parthos orbemque complesse. sed hoc non Lucii Veri vitio sed Cassii, a quo contra fidem Seleucia, quia ut amicos milites nostros receperat, expugnata est. quod quidem inter ceteros etiam Quadratus, belli Parthici scriptor, incusatis Seleucenis, qui fidem primi ruperant, purgat.*

The similarities are striking, but so too are some of the differences. Perhaps the reference to Quadratus, undoubtedly quoted by the *HA* secondhand from Maximus, suggests that Maximus had offered various historians' views on the origin of the plague.

9. 24.3.9 *animabat autem Iulianus exercitum, cum non per caritates, sed per inchoatas negotiorum magnitudines deieraret assidue: "sic sub iugum mitteret Persas, ita quassatum recrearet orbem Romanum," ut Traianus fertur aliquotiens iurando*

34 Burgess, *Jerome* (as in n. 10) 360.

35 J.F. Gilliam, "The Plague under Marcus Aurelius," *AJP* 82 (1961) 225–251.

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dicta consuesse firmare: "sic in provinciarum speciem redactas videam Dacias: sic pontibus Histrum et Aufidum superem" et similia plurima.

This passage is unparalleled, but might derive from Maximus' *Life* of Trajan.

10. 25.4.17 *[Iulianus] linguae fusioris et admodum raro silentis, praesagiorum sciscitationi nimiae deditus, ut aequiperare videretur in hac parte principem Hadrianum ...*

Hadrian's superstition is a commonplace of the historical tradition, as in Dio (Xiph.) 69.11.3-4, but as Syme pointed out it was a particular theme of Maximus' *Life* of the emperor, as in *HA Hadrian* 16.7 and particularly *Aelius* 3.9, in a passage specifically attributed to Maximus.[36]

11. 25.4.17 ... *superstitiosus magis quam sacrorum legitimus observator, innumeras sine parsimonia pecudes mactans, ut aestimaretur, si revertisset de Parthis, boves iam defuturos, Marci illius similis Caesaris, in quem id accipimus dictum: οἱ βόες οἱ λευκοὶ Μάρκῳ τῷ Καίσαρι χαίρειν / ἂν πάλι νικήσῃς, ἄμμες ἀπωλόμεθα.*

This passage is not found elsewhere, but Maximus did include comic verses about the swelling in Commodus' groin (*HA Comm.* 13.2) and specifically Greek verses attacking Elegabalus (*HA Eleg.* 11.6).

12. 26.6.8 *[Petronius] cuius morum intolerantiae haec quoque pernicies accedebat, quod, cum ditaretur luctibus alienis, erat inexorabilis et crudelis et in rapido corde rudissimus nec reddendae nec accipiendae rationis umquam capax invisior Cleandro, quem agentem sub imperatore Commodo praefecturam sublata vecordia diversas legimus vexasse fortunas, et onerosior Plautiano, qui praefectus itidem sub Severo ultra mortale tumens cuncta confuderat, ni gladio perisset ultore.*

Cleander's power and misdeeds are described extensively in *HA Comm.* Plautianus is briefly discussed in *HA Sev.* 14.5-7. See below, III.3.

13. a. 29.1.17 *ut sub principibus Commodo et Severo nonnumquam accidebat, quorum summa vi salus crebro oppugnabatur adeo, ut post intestina pericula multa et varia alter in amphitheatrali cavea, cum affuturus spectaculis introiret, a Quintiano senatore, illicitae cupidinis homine, ad debilitatem paene pugione vulneraretur ...*

    b. *... alter inopinabili impetu tempore aetatis extremo a Saturnino centurione consilio Plautiani praefecti in cubiculo iacens confoderetur, ni tulisset suppetias filius adolescens.*

Various versions of the attempts on the lives of Commodus and of Severus may be found in the *HA*, Dio, and Herodian. See below, III.4 and III.5, for discussion.

14. 21.16.11 ... *ita ille quoque ex minimis causis malorum congeries excitabat, Marci illius dissimilis principis verecundi, qui, cum ad imperiale culmen in Syria Cassius surrexisset, epistularum fascem ab eo ad conscios missum perlatore capto sibi oblatum ilico signatum exuri praecepit agens adhuc in Illyrico, ne insidiatoribus cognitis invitus quosdam habere posset offensos.*

See below, III.6, for discussion.

36 R. Syme, *Historia Augusta Papers* (as in n. 19) 81–87, and elsewhere in his work.

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15. 26.6.14 ... *fide salutis data libenter [Procopius] admissus constipatione vendibilium militum cum honore quidem, sed in modum tenebatur obsessi, qui ut praetoriani quondam post Pertinacis necem licitantem imperii praemia Iulianum susceperant, ipsi quoque Procopium infausti dominatus exordia molientem attenti ad omne compendium defenderunt.*

See below, III.7, for discussion.

16. 31.10.18-19 ... *[Gratianus] semet ad vana studia Caesaris Commodi convertisset licet hic incruentus. 19. ut enim ille, quia perimere iaculis plurimas feras spectante consueverant populo et centum leones in amphitheatrali circulo simul emissos telorum vario genere nullo geminato vulnere contruncavit, ultra hominem exultavit ...*

See below, III.8, for discussion.

III. Herodian and Dio

The works of both Herodian and Cassius Dio treat portions of the period which was covered in Ammianus' lost books. Nevertheless, a survey of the possible connections between the Greek historians and Ammianus' references suggest that they were not in fact used by Ammianus. Brok has written at length on the lack of evidence for Ammianus' use of Herodian.[37] I supplement his arguments here with further consideration of only a few passages which need elaboration. The strongest argument against Ammianus' use of Herodian, however, is his belief that there were two rather than three Gordians, an error which even a perfunctory reading of Herodian would have dispelled. The case of Dio is somewhat more difficult, since Dio survives only in fragmentary form for the period covered and since much otherwise unattested material could equally well be attributed to Maximus as to Dio. Still, some evidence does argue against the use of Dio as well. In general, one would expect the totality of Ammianus' allusions to correspond more clearly with the later Greek tradition, in writers like Zosimus and Zonaras, if he had used Dio and Herodian.

1. 22.9.5-6 (= II.4, above) Ammianus, like Herodian, digresses on the Magna Mater in the reign of Commodus. The context makes such a digression not unnatural, however, and Ammianus spoke of Nasica, who is missing from the Herodian digression.[38]
2. 28.4.21 (= II.1, above) The Quintilus brothers are described in greater detail in Dio (Xiph.), 73.5.3-7.2. They appear also in the *HA*, however, and the nature of Ammianus' ironic reference to them in his Roman digression demands that they be known proverbially to his audience.
3. 26.6.8 (= II.12, above) Plautianus was discussed in *HA Sev.* 14.5-7, but the specific details of his death are found only in Herodian and Dio. Presumably Marius Maximus did not omit his death and could therefore be Ammianus' source.

37 M.F.A. Brok, "Un malentendu tenace (Les rapports entre Hérodien et Ammien Marcellin)," *REA* 78/9 (1976/7) 199–207.

38 Brok, *malentendu tenace* (as in n. 35) 204–205.

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4. 29.1.17 (= II.13a, above) These events are variously discussed by Herodian 1.8.5-6, Dio (Xiph.) 72.4.4-5, and *HA Comm.* 4.2-4.[39] In Herodian, he is called Quintianus, in Dio and the *HA*, Pompeianus. Presumably Maximus had his full name, Claudius Pompeianus Quintinianus (*PIR*^{2} C 975).

While Herodian had claimed this was the first attempt on Commodus' life, Ammianus says it occurred after many previous attempts. Herodian has the senator hide in the shadows *ἐν τῇ ἀμφιθεάτρου εἰσόδῳ*, which is not the same location as the *cavea* of the amphitheater where Ammianus places him. In Herodian, Commodus is explicitly unharmed; neither Dio nor the *HA* suggests that Commodus was badly wounded, as Ammianus claims. The *illicitae cupidinis* has been understood as a reference to the account of Dio, which claims that he had had sexual relations with both Lucilla and her daughter, to whom he was engaged; on the other hand, the phrase could be translated as in the Loeb simply as "a man of unlawful ambition." To sum up, Ammianus' brief reference contains items found in each of the Greek historians, and in neither. Rather than argue that Ammianus has somehow melded the different accounts of Dio and Herodian, or misremembered his source(s) in some way, it is preferable to posit another, different source. The obvious one is Marius Maximus.

5. 29.1.17 (= II.13b, above) Saturninus is not mentioned in the *HA*, but can be found in Dio (Xiph.) 76.3 and Herodian 3.11.[40] Dio agrees with Ammianus that Saturninus was a centurion, whereas Herodian claims he was a tribune. On the other hand, Dio claims that the plot was engineered by Caracalla in order to discredit Plautianus, which is clearly opposed to Ammianus' version here. Again Ammianus' version demands a melding of the two Greek historians or another source altogether; and again that other source is most obviously Maximus.
6. 21.16.11 (= II.14, above) Dio (Xiph.) 72.29 discusses these letters as well, but with significant differences. In Ammianus, the revolt of Cassius is still underway, and Marcus is in Illyricum, when he orders the destruction of the letters which had fallen into his hands as a result of the taking of a prisoner. In Dio, after the deaths of Cassius and Faustina, Marcus orders the destruction of papers found in the chest of Pudens; or, alternately, Verus has papers discovered in Syria destroyed of his own accord. Clearly Ammianus is not using Dio here.
7. 26.6.14 (= II.15, above) The Greek sources are clear and full on the auction which resulted in the transfer of power to Didius Julianus (Dio [Xiph.] 74.11, Herodian 2.6.4-12), while the *HA* (*DJ* 2.5-7) and *KG* (Victor 19; Eut. 8.16) at best allude to the story.[41] It seems that Maximus, and therefore the *KG*, took a softer line on Didius Julianus. Ammianus does seem more in tune with the Greek sources here, although it is a matter of tone rather than content. Comparison with Ausonius is illuminating (*Caes.* 20). The poet expresses a negative view of the emperor although he depends upon the Latin sources, and he incidentally mirrors Ammianus' use of the word *praemia* for the "prize" of power.
8. 31.10.18-19 (= II.16, above) The HA (*Comm.* 12.12, 13.3) records Commodus' infamous gladiatorial skill, including the fact that he frequently killed animals with a single blow. The clearest parallel is found in Herodian, however:[42] *λεόντων δέ*

39 Brok, *malentendu tenace* (as in n. 35) 206–207.
40 Gilliam, *Ammianus* (as in n. 1) 137.
41 J.B. Leaning, "Didius Julianus and his Biographer," *Latomus* 48 (1989) 548–565.
42 Gilliam, *Ammianus* (as in n. 1) 135 n. 26.

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ποτε ἐξ ὑπογαίων ἑκατὸν ἀναρριφθέντων ἰσαρίθμοις ἀκοντίοις πάντας ἀπ-ἔκτεινεν (1.15.6).[43] Herodian agrees on the hundred lions and hundred blows, although he does have a hundred spears laid out for inspection, against Ammianus' *telorum vario genere*. The coincidence is not as strong as it appears, however, for the slaughter of a hundred animals at one time was quite common. Dio records that Commodus killed 100 bears (72.18.1-2) and Hadrian had 100 lions and 100 lionesses killed (69.8.2). Pius is said to have had 100 lions killed as well (*HA Pius* 10.9). The *KG* recorded the slaying of a hundred lions in the reign of Marcus (*HA Marc.* 17.7, Eut. 8.14.1, Jerome 208). Commodus' slaughter may have occurred (Herodian may have been an eyewitness) and been reported in Marius Maximus, or a stereotypically exceptional exploit of the amphitheater may have become attached to the quintessential emperor-gladiator.

IV. Eunapius, or his source

In the passages collected below, Ammianus preserves information which is found in the later Greek sources, including Zosimus, Cedrenus, and the *Anonymus post Dionem*, but not in the Latin tradition. The relative paucity of such passages constitutes a problem. If Ammianus used a Greek source for third- and early fourth-century history, far more parallels between his work and the later Greek sources would presumably exist. In addition, Ammianus would have avoided elementary mistakes, such as his belief in two rather than three Gordians, and would have been able to avoid dependence on the substandard *KG* altogether.

Ammianus' source for these passages must, then, have been brief and perhaps lacking in narrative context. In addition, it was probably an anti-Christian source, since the passages include criticism of the Christian Constantine, the persecuting Decii, and Philip the Arab, whom the fourth century considered a crypto-Christian. An obvious candidate for this source is Eunapius, the anti-Christian contemporary of Ammianus whose first book provides a quick summary of Roman history from 270 to 355.[44] Parallels between Ammianus' account of the Persian invasion of Julian and that of Zosimus, who closely followed Eunapius in this section of his work, have long been noted, but their significance has been disputed.[45] The dispute has been further complicated by questions of the relative priority of the two works; the fact that Eunapius' history appeared in at least two editions has resulted in a wide range of theories concerning the relationships between Eunapius, Ammianus, and our other sources.[46] Ammianus' work differs enough from that of Eunapius to make extensive borrowing in either direction unlikely, but the passages below could be garnered solely from the first, introductory volume, so that no familiarity with the rest of the work would be necessary.

43 Note that the text is generally emended, following Reisk, with the Ammianus passage in mind, with <*ἅμα*> *ἀφθέντων* replacing *ἀναρριφθέντων*.

44 R.C. Blockley, *The Fragmentary Classicising Historians of the Later Roman Empire* I (Liverpool, 1981) 7.

45 C.W. Fornara, "Julian's Persian Expedition in Ammianus and Zosimus," *JHS* 111 (1991) 1–15 has full survey and bibliography, although he argues against any connection between the two authors.

46 T.D. Barnes, *Sources (1978)* (as in n. 6) 114–123; F. Paschoud, *Zosime: Histoire Nouvelle* III.2 (Paris, 1989) 82–100.

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On the other hand, western material found in Zosimus and derived from Eunapius, as well as linguistic and other parallels, suggest that Eunapius may have been dependent upon a Latin, senatorial source for part of his work, whose tracks have been spotted throughout the later Greek tradition.[47] Bruno Bleckmann calls this source the "Leo-quelle," since he sees traces of it in the tenth-century historian Leo the Grammarian, and he identifies it with the late-fourth-century senator Nicomachus Flavianus, who is known to have written *Annales*. If such a source existed, Ammianus may well have bypassed Eunapius and used it directly, especially considering his apparent preference for Latin-language histories. But the passages I group under this heading do not serve to distinguish between Eunapius and a pagan, western source.

1. 25.4.23 *et quoniam eum obtrectatores novos bellorum tumultus ad perniciem rei communis insimulant concitasse, sciant docente veritate perspicue non Iulianum, sed Constantinum ardores Parthicos succendisse, cum Metrodori mendaciis avidius acquiescit, ut dudum rettulimus plene.*

While the philosopher Metrodorus is mentioned in neutral terms by Jerome (232h) and Rufinus *HE* 10.9 (the latter followed by Socrates 1.19.3 and Sozomen 2.24), the story to which Ammianus must allude is only elaborated by the eleventh-century chronicler Cedrenus 1.295a–b (Bonn). The purpose of the tale is to remove guilt for the failure of the Persian expedition from Julian and attach it to Constantine. Warmington argues that the obvious source of such an anti-Christian and suspect story is Eunapius.[48] Eunapius' Latin source could also be Ammianus' source.

2. 27.3.7 *quo vitio laborasse Traianus dicitur princeps, unde eum herbam parietinam iocando cognominarunt.*

This description of Trajan is attributed to the emperor Constantine, according to *Epit.* 41.13; it is also found in the *Anonymus post Dionem*, *Excerpta Vaticana* 191. Barnes has argued that the Epitomator used Eunapius; such a theory would explain the presence of the anecdote in all three places.[49] Alternatively, this could be derived from the Latin source of Eunapius, whom Schlumberger and Paschoud have argued was also a source for the Epitomator.[50]

3. a. 31.5.16 *ceciderunt dimicando cum barbaris imperatores Decii pater et filius.*
   b. 31.13.13 *simili clade Caesarem accipimus Decium dimicantem cum barbaris acriter equi lapsu prostratum, quem ferventem retinere non valuit, abiectumque in paludem nec emergere potuisse nec inveniri.*
   c. 23.5.17 (= I.6b, above)
   d. 26.6.20 (= I.6c, above)
   e. 14.1.8 (= I.6d, above)

47 B. Bleckmann, *Die Reichskrise des III. Jahrhunderts in der spätantiken und byzantinischen Geschichtsschreibung* (Munich 1992); F. Paschoud, "Nicomaque Flavien et la connexion byzantine (Pierre le Patrice et Zonaras): à propos du récent livre de Bruno Bleckmann," *Antiquité Tardive* 2 (1994) 71–82.

48 B.H. Warmington, "Ammianus Marcellinus and the Lies of Metrodorus," *CQ* NS 31 (1981) 464–468.

49 Barnes, *Epitome* (as in n. 10) 267.

50 J. Schlumberger, *Die Epitome de Caesaribus* (Munich 1974); F. Paschoud, *Cinq études sur Zosime* (Paris 1975) 100–183.

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Ammianus preserves several details about the Decii and the Gordians which were apparently not found in the *KG*, but which are paralleled in the Greek sources or the *Historia Augusta*. The source(s) for his information on the Gordians is most challenging. At first glance, Herodian would appear to be the obvious source. As noted above, however, it is difficult to imagine Ammianus using Herodian without discovering the true number of Gordians, as the author of the *Historia Augusta* did. Also, Herodian does not mention the wife of Maximinus, so that Ammianus would require still another source for this information in any case.

Ammianus' source for the additional material on the Gordians must either be one which also is ignorant of the true number of Gordians, or, as I argue here, must present the material outside of a narrative context. Eunapius, or his source, is the obvious candidate. The claim that the Decii lost their lives in a swamp is not found in the *KG* sources, but is in the Greek sources (Zos. 1.23). This, too, may derive from Eunapius, or the *Leoquelle*.

The Decii and Gordian III both present models of heroic, pagan emperors fighting on behalf of the empire. Such material would provide irresistable foreshadowing of the career and death of Julian for any aggressively pagan fourth-century historian.

V. Antiochene material

Ammianus provides a few details of second- and third-century history which concern Antioch and which in one case is paralleled only in other Antiochene sources. These details are not, perhaps, from written sources, but represent the oral history of his city of origin.

1. 23.5.3 *namque cum Antiochiae in alto silentio scaenicis ludis mimus cum uxore immissus e medio dempta quaedam imitaretur populo venustate attonito, coniunx "nisi somnus est," inquit, "en Persae," et retortis plebs universa cervicibus exacerbantia in se tela declinans spargitur passim. ita civitate incensa et obtruncatis pluribus, qui pacis more palabantur effusius, incensisque locis finitimis et vastatis onusti praeda hostes ad sua remearunt innoxii Mariade vivo exusto, qui eos ad suorum interitum civium duxerat inconsulte. et haec quidem Gallieni temporibus evenerunt.*

Potter discusses the incident and its sources at length.[51] Of particular interest is the fact that Libanius alludes to the story twice (24.38, 60.2), "which suggests that it was current in late fourth-century Antioch."

2. 22.12.8 *haecque dum ita procedunt more pacis multorum curiosior Iulianus novam consilii viam ingressus est venas fatidicas Castalii recludere cogitans fontis, quem obstruxisse Caesar dicitur Hadrianus mole saxorum ingenti veritus, ne, ut ipse praecinentibus aquis capessendam rem publicam comperit, etiam alii similia docerentur ...*

The story appears elsewhere only in the church historian Sozomen (5.17), in the course of a digression which makes clear his personal knowledge of the site and the mythology

51 Potter, *Prophecy* (as in n. 22) 268–273.

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surrounding Daphne, the surburb of Antioch where the spring was located. This is the sort of information which one gets from tour guides, perhaps.

3. 14.1.9 *novo denique perniciosoque exemplo idem Gallus ausus est inire flagitium grave, quod Romae cum ultimo dedecore temptasse aliquando dicitur Gallienus, et adhibitis paucis clam ferro succinctis versperi per tabernas palabatur et compita quaeritando Graeco sermone, cuius erat impendio gnarus, quid de Caesare quisque sentiret.*

No other source mentions this. It is not a back-reference, and I suspect that the claim, which resembles behavior attributed to Nero by Suetonius (*Ner.* 26), is simply an oral legend which was easily attached to stereotypically wicked emperors. Although the anecdote supposedly took place at Rome, its lack of parallels in other sources suggests that it arose at Antioch during discussions of Gallus' behavior.

VI. Other

1. 22.4.8 *notum est enim sub Maximiano Caesare vallo regis Persarum direpto gregarium quendam sacculum Parthicum, in quo erant margaritae, repertum proiectis imperitia gemmis abisse pellis nitore solo contentum.*

The folktale motif and the introduction *notum est* suggest that this has an oral source.

2. 22.5.4-5 *[Iulianus] saepeque dictitabat: "audite me, quem Alamanni audierunt et Franci" imitari putans Marci principis veteris dictum. sed parum advertit hoc ab eo nimium discrepare. 6. ille enim cum Palaestinam transiret Aegyptum petens, Iudaeorum fetentium et tumultuantium saepe taedio percitus dolenter dicitur exclamasse: "o Marcomanni, o Quadi, o Sarmatae, tandem alios vobis inquietores inveni."*

The source of this might be a geographic or ethnographic work, rather than a historical work; it is not found elsewhere. It might, of course, also stem from Marius Maximus.

3. 16.10.16 *cui prope astans regalis Hormisdas, cuius e Perside discessum supra monstravimus, respondit astu gentili ...*

John of Antioch writes that Hormisdas fled to the emperor Licinius (*fr.* 178, 1 Mueller), presumably in 324; Zosimus, in an account filled with folklore, says that Hormisdas fled to Constantine (2.27). The story of how a Persian prince came to be fighting on behalf of the Roman empire in a time contemporary with Ammianus' own military service would be a subject of interest to any historian and a likely topic of barracks-conversation. Ursicinus, for example, would surely know the true story. There is no reason to think that Ammianus' version would correspond with that of Zosimus, as some have argued.[52]

52 E.g., F. Paschoud, *Zosime: Histoire Nouvelle* I[2] (Paris 2000) 232–233.

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VII. Conclusions

This simple model suggests that Ammianus used Marius Maximus as his source until its end, at which point he used Enmann's *Kaisergeschichte* until he had reached a period of history sufficiently contemporary to use oral and documentary sources in addition to any more formal histories available to him. This minimalism should not surprise us. First, Ammianus was not primarily an ancient historian and did not seek the best possible evidence for the past. Ancient history was a platform upon which he could provide models and commentary for his work of contemporary history, and one narrative was nearly as good as the next for this purpose. The simple fact that he used the *KG* should have provided a clue that his coverage was neither detailed nor especially concerned with accuracy. Second, Ammianus' literary and historical culture was Latin, not Greek, as Fornara has demonstrated, and it is unsurprising that he should rely upon Latin sources for his own work.[53]

This reconstruction has important ramifications for judging the quality of the lost books. The third-century history which Ammianus drew from the *KG* is largely extant in the epitomators, and we would not expect much more from the lost books. Ammianus' selection of material from Marius Maximus would undoubtedly have been both different and more careful than that of the *Historia Augusta*, and would surely enrich our knowledge of the period. The real loss, however, consists of the books where Ammianus covered the first half of the fourth century and used his skills as a contemporary historian.

Investigation of the true back-references in Ammianus' surviving books led Robert Frakes to two important observations.[54] First, a large percentage of back-references are to events during the reign of Constantine and later. Of the 35 on Frakes's list, 18 refer to the reign of Constantine or, more often, to his successors. While it would perhaps be natural to refer to more recent events more often, this still reveals the amount of detail which Ammianus provided in his fourth-century narrative. Second, a surprising number of back-references to the second and third centuries are digressive, eleven in all. This suggests that Ammianus provides at least as much geographical, ethnographical, and other digressive material in the lost books as we find in the surviving books, and suggests that the narrative comprehensiveness of the lost books was even less than the available space might indicate. Only six of Frakes's true back references (14.1.8; 23.5.7; 23.6.24; 25.8.5 [x2]; 29.6.1) appear to have been to narrative accounts of second- and third-century history.

What was the length and scope of the lost books? In 1989, John Matthews expressed the opinion that the lost books of Ammianus served as "little more than a substantial introduction" to the contemporary part of the work.[55] More recent work has argued that the lost books were more full. Barnes claims that "Ammianus cannot have compressed his history of the Roman Empire from 96 to 353 into a mere thirteen books."[56] The obvious response to Barnes's claim is, Why not? Both Aurelius Victor

53 C.W. Fornara, "Ammianus' Knowledge and Use of Greek and Latin Literature," *Historia* 41 (1992) 420–438.

54 R.M. Frakes, "Ammianus Marcellinus and Osroëne," *AHB* 7 (1993) 143–147; Id., "Ammianus Marcellinus XXI.16.7: A Re-examination," *Hermes* 122 (1994) 253–256; Id., *Cross-References* (as in n. 1); Id., *Some Thoughts* (as in n. 1).

55 Matthews, *Roman Empire* (as in n. 1) 30.

56 Barnes, *Ammianus* (as in n. 1) 28.

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and Eutropius covered an equivalent period of time in far fewer than thirteen books. Since this study suggests that Ammianus used only a couple of Latin sources, the "problem" would seem to be that there is too much, not too little, space in the lost books. Barnes has suggested that there were an additional five books among those lost, in part to provide more room for Ammianus' history of the earlier empire, and in part to preserve an arrangement of books in hexads and avoid the asymmetrical count of 31 books for the work as a whole. The case for the traditional numeration remains strong, however, because of the grammarian Priscian's sixth-century identification of book fourteen, and the unusual total of 31 books has a plausible explanation. Since Tacitus' *Annals* and *Histories* circulated as a combined work of 30 books in the fourth century, according to Jerome (*comm. in Zech.* 3.14), Ammianus apparently sought to outdo his predecessor with the addition of an extra book.

Robert Frakes concluded that "Ammianus' lost books were likely quite long and in-depth" (2000: 53). Frakes calculated that the average length of the surviving books was roughly 32 Teubner pages. Avoiding complex statistical reasoning, we may estimate very roughly that the first 13 books would have therefore filled around 400 pages. The surviving history cover 25 years in 18 books, for an average of 1.39 years per book. Some of these books cover less than a year's time, in order to better glorify Julian and his exploits, so we should not see this ratio as normal even for Ammianus' contemporary history. At some point the history must have shifted from narrative constructed only from previously written sources to history composed from oral and documentary sources as well. A source for Ammianus' history, the eunuch Eutherius, was raised in the palace of Constantine, and then served his successors (Amm. 16.7); sometime during the reign of Constantine would reasonably mark the outer limit of Ammianus' ability to use contemporary methods. Let us arbitrarily assign four years to each book back to the death of Constantine in 337, which would cover books 10–13, and about ten years to each book on the reign of Constantine, which would cover books 7–9. This leaves us with books 1–6, about 180 pages, covering history from 96–306 wholly from written sources at a rate of 35 years per book. The Teubner edition of Suetonius is 360 pages long; if Marius Maximus was comparable, much room remained for compression. Since Ammianus clearly provided a great deal of ethnographic and geographic digression, the amount of historical narration would have been commensurably less.

Ammianus sought to connect his work with the imperial past, both in historiographical terms, as a successor to Tacitus, and in historical terms, to link Julian and the fourth-century empire to the world of the second and third century. He aimed, as well, at a geographical, ethnographical, and historical completeness which his extant work likewise demonstrates. None of these goals required the careful sorting of numerous ancient historians, and this study suggests that no such procedure was followed.

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